

ments. It was felt that new techniques were required to provide novel experiences to the target audience.

Use of VR and AR for marketing changed the playing field dramatically. Leading businesses are incorporating AR or VR, or both, as part of their digital marketing strategy to attract customers, promote their products, increase sales, retain customers and provide unique experiences to shoppers. Their use is growing across various industries, be it healthcare, medicine, astronomy, education, defence or consumer goods.

AR and VR technologies enable integration of digital technology with marketing strategies, transforming the shopping experience to a new level.

AR is relatively more effective as it involves lower costs and helps customers in making shopping decisions while engaged with the content. AR and VR also provide in-store experience in the comfort of home without having to physically visit the marketplace. e-Commerce platforms are increasingly using AR to enable customers to experience the product as if present in the real-life setting. Use of AR and VR in retail stores, e-commerce and advertising is the next big thing ready to disrupt marketing concepts.

Artificial reality marketing (ARM) is a multi-media promotional activity that encourages interaction between the customer and the brand, creating a greater level of emotional engagement, increasing customer loyalty, enhancing publicity and building long-term relationships. Businesses integrate these technologies into marketing strategies for providing richer and more realistic feel of their prod-



Lowe created VR experience Holoroom where customers can virtually test different types of tools (Credit: www.roadtovr.com)

ucts (AR catwalks, AR showrooms), for enabling shoppers to try-on products (AR mirrors) and for raising awareness of their brand (creative and interactive AR campaigns). AR and VR technologies provide shoppers an opportunity to explore products and customise them to their liking.

For example, while shopping for a car, users can try out different colours, check out features and manoeuvre the car through a virtual test drive. **Realtors use VR to design virtual tours to provide 360-degree walkthrough of the property, try out different paint colours on the walls or simply add furniture to experience how the property will actually look.** ARM combines traditional advertising with mobile devices to attract customers' attention by projecting 3D images of products onto the screen of their mobile devices, offering them a unique and personal experience.

ARM campaigns need to be aligned with the company's objective, be utility-oriented and offer a valuable experience to customers. For example, Burberry store in London provides an interactive and

exclusive experience to its customers. Hundred screens with 500 speakers enable them to interact with the store. Mirrors with cameras get transformed into screens displaying live video of the customer wearing the product, giving a glimpse of how well a product fits on the customer.

LEGO uses ARM during the pre-purchase

phase of marketing. In store, a virtual model of the LEGO toy can be created, which gets projected on the package when it is presented to the camera of the LEGO kiosk. Once the LEGO toy is built, the customer is able to bring the creation to life using LEGO Storyteller app.

AR has been successfully used with brochures and catalogues, too. On mobile devices using AR app product information and features can be seen. **Automaker Audi created an AR brochure offering customers interactive experience that allowed them to explore the virtual cockpit of 2016 Audi TT.** Lowe created VR experience Holoroom using HTC Vive VR headset. Using it, customers could virtually test different types of tools and equipment and pick DIY skills.

AR and VR in retail

Using VR technology, retailers can create simulated experiences to capture the curiosity of shoppers and share their brand story with them. The technology helps them stand out from the competition, attract more customers and boost sales.

John Lewis, a UK-based departmental store, ran a VR campaign, Monty's Christmas, about a young boy Sam and his best friend, Monty the Penguin, to promote their holiday campaign. The experience allowed children as well as adults to explore the story of Monty and Sam using a Google Cardboard VR headset. The campaign boosted sales and left a lasting impression, making customers eager to visit again during the next season.

Outdoor apparel company, Merrell launched VR campaign TrailScape,



A customer scans a product using AR, inside a retail store (Credit: YouTube)